

Countability

A Quick-Reference Guide

Narrative Blurb

Countability is sometimes reduced to a single simplistic point or distinction:

1. Solid objects that you can count, are "countable" and use one set of words.
2. Liquids and gases that you cannot "count the parts of" are called "uncountable" and use another set of words.

However:

A) That distinction has no clear and practical definition:

(The following is a mess, and probably wrong anyway:)

e.g.

1. Not-clearly-separable substances, composts, or functional devices, physical or immaterial, without moderately large units or subunits in structure, are "uncountable"
2. quantifiable wholes that are at least large enough to be easily be handled and exchanged individually, and which are named outside of the name of the composing material, are called countable.

B) There are many types of exceptions: e.g.

1. There are exceptions for nouns/items:

Sea (usually something countable has to be at least vaguely clear):

This is a sea, but it has no clear boundaries.

There are two seas, they look like one blob.

Water (usually the name of a material is uncountable, or a specific object (a metal of honor, a glass for wine):

These women have sailed the waters between here and Albany.

2. There several are linguistic exceptions where the language does not follow that or any binary distinction at all.

(see the chart of 8 categories)